

BASIC RESEARCH METHODS AND TOOLS · SPRING 2026

Evaluating the Effectiveness of KIU's Internship Support Services for Undergraduate Students

Kutaisi International University · School of Computer Science

Nikoloz Modebadze · Mariam Pkhaladze · Tinatin Javakhadze ·
Lasha Giorgi Tskhadadze · Luka Mekoshvili · Davit Tcheishvili

Date of submission: 09/07/2026

Why internship support matters and why it can fail quietly

- A proven bridge to a career:

but only if students can find and land one.

- Universities try to help:

announcements, CV help, interview prep.

- The paradox:

only about a third of students ever use career support.

- At KIU, nobody knew if this held

THE CORE TENSION

A support service only works if students

Know it exists → use it → find it useful

Break any link, and the service fails quietly, regardless of its quality.

Research Question

How effective do KIU undergraduate students perceive KIU's internship support services to be in helping them find, prepare for, and apply to internships?

Find

awareness and discovery
of opportunities

Prepare

CVs, interviews, and
employer expectations

Apply

application support and
follow-through

Hypotheses

Grouping variable: *used_support* (Yes / No)

Outcome: *readiness_score* (mean of 4 items)

H₀ — Null Hypothesis

There is no significant difference in perceived internship readiness between students who have used KIU internship support services and students who have not.

H₁ — Alternative Hypothesis

Students who have used KIU internship support services report **significantly higher** perceived internship readiness than students who have not.

Five themes that shaped the study

1

Employability frameworks

CareerEDGE ties support to self-efficacy and confidence, not just skills. This concept forms the basis for our readiness measure.

2

Internships build employability

But the payoff depends on placement quality and support structure, not the internship alone.

3

Unequal access

The “thwarted intern” literature: barriers to internships are structural, not motivational.

4

The satisfaction–utilisation paradox

~33% of students ever use centralised career services, even when most feel supported.

5

The research gap

No evidence exists for a small, non-Western institution like KIU — this study fills that gap.

Study design at a glance

DESIGN

Quantitative,
cross-sectional survey

PLATFORM

Google Forms,
1–5 Likert scale

SAMPLE

122 valid responses,
convenience sampling

POPULATION

CS, Management, Math
2nd, 3rd and 4th year

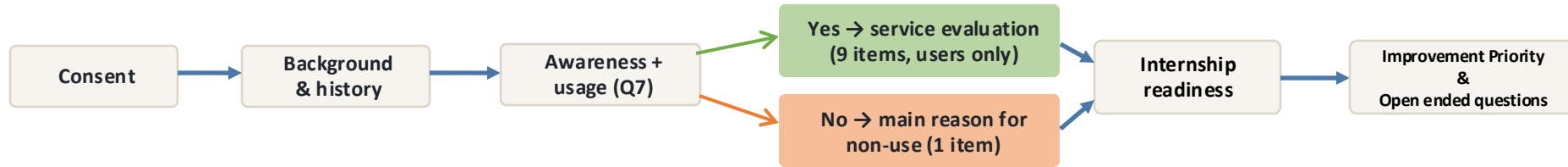
WINDOW

28 June – 8 July 2026
(11 days)

ANALYSIS

Python (pandas, SciPy)
Descriptive stats i.e.
Welch t-test

Survey structure and branching



All consenting respondents → 4 readiness items → improvement priority → 2 optional open-ended questions

Every Likert item uses the same 1–5 scale: 1 = Strongly disagree, 5 = Strongly agree.

RESULTS

Who answered the survey

N = 122

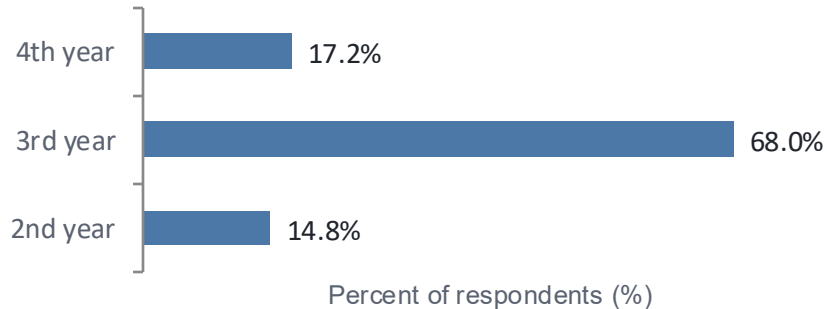
valid, consenting responses
(none excluded)

78.7% had searched for an internship

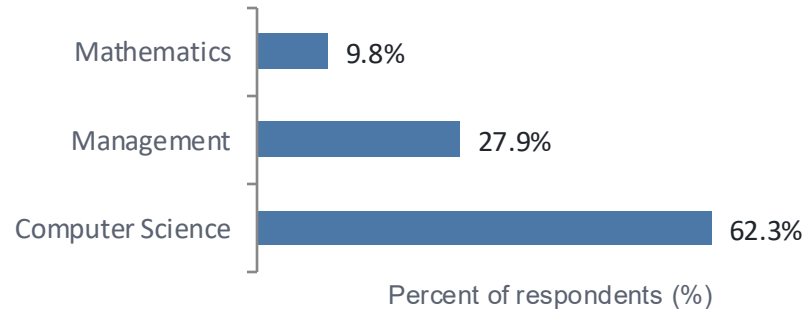
33.6% had completed one

31.1% had used KIU support

By year of study

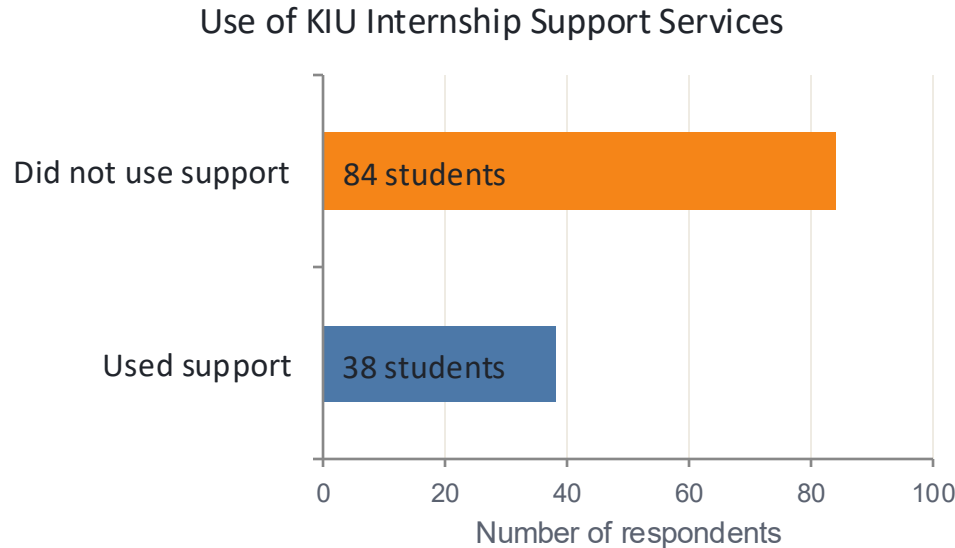


By school



RESULTS

Awareness and usage



31.1% used support · **68.9%** did not

Awareness score:

M = 2.92, SD = 1.32

below the scale midpoint (3.0)

TOP REASONS FOR NON-USE (n = 84)

32.1% didn't know the services existed

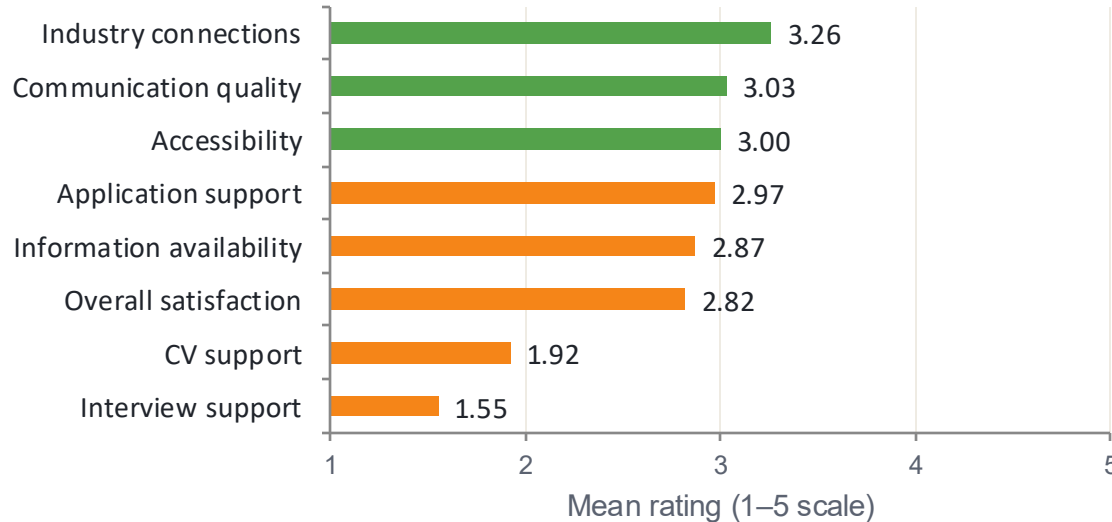
21.4% didn't seem relevant to their field

19.0% didn't know how to access them

RESULTS

How support users rated specific services

Mean Service-Evaluation Ratings Among Support Users (n = 38)



Bars **green** ≥ 3.0 (at least neutral) · **orange** < 3.0

Among the 38 users

Composite satisfaction

$M = 2.68$, $SD = 0.56$, $\alpha = .77$

Best-rated

Industry connections (3.26)

Worst-rated

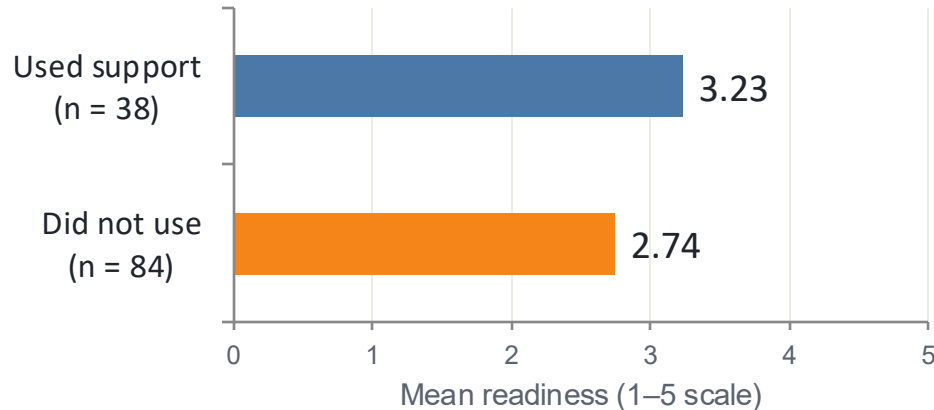
Interview prep (1.55), CV support (1.92)

94.7% of users only ever used the announcement channel
(very few experienced hands-on prep)

RESULTS

Readiness by service usage the hypothesis test

Mean readiness score by support usage



H_0 rejected at $\alpha = .05$ i.e. the difference is significant

+0.50 points

Mean difference

95% CI [0.20, 0.79]

d = 0.60

Cohen's d

medium effect size

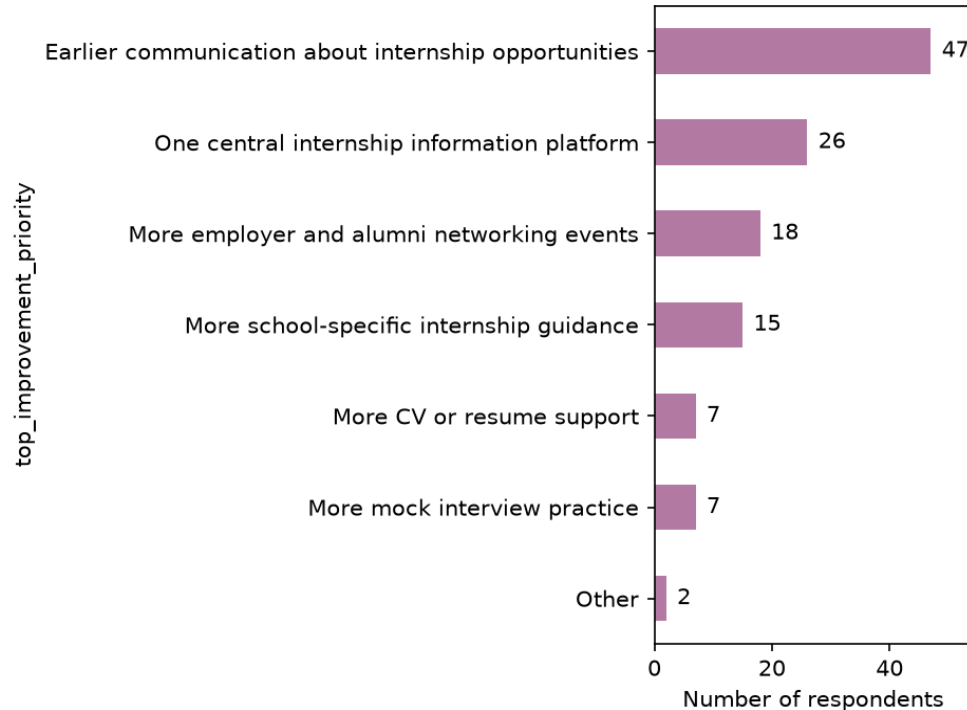
p = .001

Welch t(88.1) = 3.36

independent-samples t-test

RESULTS

What students want fixed first



“We don't get any tips on how to prepare CVs or for interviews.”

OPEN-ENDED THEMES

(76 weaknesses · 70 suggestions)

- Low awareness / visibility
- Late communication
- Field-mismatched opportunities
- Lack of practical preparation

Potentially effective, but largely invisible

- **The services work when used:** medium effect size ($d = 0.60$) on readiness, and awareness correlates with readiness ($r = .43$).
- **But most students never touch them:** 31.1% usage, awareness below the midpoint, and the top reason for non-use is simply not knowing.
- **It matches the international paradox:** 31.1% almost exactly reproduces the ~33% figure reported for UK career services.
- **It contradicts the usual pattern:** Western students are typically most satisfied with CV / interview help — at KIU that's the weakest area, most likely because it's barely delivered, not delivered badly.

Limitations

- 1 Convenience sample skewed toward 3rd-year CS students (68% / 62.3%)
- 2 Cross-sectional design → association, not causation
- 3 Self-selection is a plausible confound
(proactive students may both seek support and feel ready)
- 4 Self-reported perceptions, not actual placement outcomes
- 5 Custom instrument, piloted with only 2 students
- 6 Single small institution (limits generalisability)

Recommendations

1

Communicate earlier and more visibly

the #1 student priority (38.5%) *(and the cheapest fix)*

2

Build one central internship platform

so information doesn't depend on students noticing an email

3

Actually deliver CV & interview prep

not just announcements *(this is where ratings are lowest)*

4

Build field-specific partnerships

for Management and Mathematics students, who report the most mismatch

CONCLUSION

KIU's internship support is promising but under-promoted and underdeveloped in practical preparation.

- **Users report significantly higher readiness** than non-users ($t(88.1) = 3.36, p = .001, d = 0.60$).
- **Only 31.1% of students** have ever used a KIU support service.
- **Fix visibility first**, then hands-on preparation
future work should test this with a pre-post design.

Questions?